

brat summer of code

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Abstract

Every year, there are several ‘Summer of Code’-style initiatives available to students, hobbyists, and early-career developers that encourage developmental growth and open-source contribution. In this brief paper, we propose an alternative set of values for these seasonal sessions to develop, ones that are instead grounded in real life skills — giving participants opportunities to disregard established software engineering principles, ignore code reviews, bypass required tests and ultimately, think for themselves.

Be Messy

Being messy is both an art and a privilege. We all need the experience of pushing bugs to production, choosing inappropriate placeholder values¹² in our code and creating a dozen half-finished projects. And what would be better than having a designated space where participants can experience this and leave guilt-free at the end of the summer?

If no-one was messy, nothing would ever change. The Balmer’s Peak would never have been discovered, and probably a load of your participants might never have even been born!

Give zero fucks

Confidence is an important soft skill for developers to nurture and it’s important for them to realize — No-one can fire you from open source contributions. You’re allowed to take ciggy breaks. No-one cares if you don’t wear pants or don’t shower when you are remote. And skipping documentation and hardcoding shit is pretty freaking common. When you throw away all the rules, you learn which ones were actually there for a reason, but importantly which ones are overrated as shit. Empower the future workforce with a space to fuck around and find out.

Listen to noone but yourself

Let’s encourage developers to hack on stuff that they think is cool, not what some corporate sponsor thinks they should do. Are project maintainers being assholes? Give your participants the confidence to Fork off!

The best work comes from passion not fuzzy concepts like ‘Best Practises’. Look back at any early stage unicorn start up and realise — it’s all a hot mess. Accept it. What’s the likelihood anyone will even realise you’ve saved your admin passwords in plaintext anyway?

¹For hex values, we recommend 0xB00B5135 and calling things 0xDADD1E.

²lorem ipsum? more like lorem ipBUM! (raucous applause)